and execute his vision for India@100 long after he has laid down office. Nitin Gadkari, Amit Shah and Rajnath Singh emerge as the best-performing ministers in the Modi cabinet in the MOTN survey. Shah, Yogi Adityanath and Gadkari are also the preferred options to succeed Modi, in addition to Rajnath Singh and Nirmala Sitharaman. But none of them has the charisma and stature Modi enjoys across the country, and that is something the party and its mentor, the RSS, must ponder over.

The crux for the Modi government, which the MOTN points to, should be to address the public's pain points, especially on the economic front. The argument that if there was so much economic distress, public protest should have broken out, is fallacious. When the Agniveer scheme was introduced, there were spontaneous riots across many states by aspirants who felt that the government was shortchanging them on employment. It was a pointer to the many bottled-up frustrations that could combust unexpectedly. The shock and awe tactics employed in passing the farm laws as well as the Agniveer scheme through overnight announcements have proved to be counterproductive.

Perhaps the current prime minister can take a leaf out of former prime minister Manmohan Singh's book by setting up high-powered crisis management groups to deal with issues such as the rupee's devaluation, oil imports, price rise, the fallout of the Ukraine crisis, rebuilding the small-scale sector and creating jobs. Modi did exactly that during the pandemic to manage every aspect of the crisis, be it hospital beds, test kits, personal protection equipment or vaccines, which proved quite effective.

MODI HAS MAINTAINED **A FINE BALANCE** BETWEEN HINDUTVA, WELFARISM AND HYPERNATIONALISM

Doing so would bring more cohesion in managing key issues, especially among his cabinet colleagues who tend to operate in silos and take direction directly from the prime minister. The PM's initiative to start a Gati Shakti portal that brings all key ministries and stakeholders together to coordinate infrastructure development is a step in the right direction.

So far, Modi has in his eight years as prime minister managed to maintain the fine balance between focusing on development and welfarism and delivering on the Hindutva agenda. If the economy continues to slide, the BJP may be tempted to fall back on the default option of polarising the electorate to win in 2024. Modi must eschew that temptation. The biggest takeaway from this MOTN is that the government needs to set the economy right and put India firmly back on the high growth track. Modi has the experience, the political acumen, the wherewithal and the charisma to guide India out of the current abyss. The current MOTN shows that people not only trust him but are also betting on him to succeed. He must not fail us. ■

METHODOLOGY

The India Today Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll was conducted by CVoter, a globally renowned name in the field of socio-economic research, between July 15, 2022, and July 31, 2022, interviewing 22,861 respondents covering all Lok Sabha segments across all states. In addition to these samples, an additional 96,676 interviews from CVoter's regular tracker data between February 2022 and July 2022 were also analysed for the long-term trendline in projected calculations of votes and seats. With the fast-changing situation in Bihar, a dynamic Snap Poll of 2,479 respondents was carried out on August 9 to assess the impact of the new ground equations on the national numbers. Thus, the opinion of 122,016 respondents was considered for this MOTN report. The margin of error is +/- 3 per cent at the macro level and +/- 5 per cent at micro-level reporting, with 95 per cent confidence level.

From May 2009 onwards, the CVoter Tracker has been carried out each week, 52 waves in a calendar year, in 11 national languages, across all states and UTs in India, with a target sample size of 30,000 samples each quarter. The average response rate is 55 per cent. Starting January 1, 2019, CVoter has been carrying the tracker on a daily basis, using the rolling sample of seven days for tracker analysis.

All these polls are based on a random probability sample as used in the globally standardised methodology, carried out by trained researchers across all geographic and demographic segments. This survey is based on CATI interviews of adult respondents across all segments. Standard RDD is used to draw random numbers covering all frequency series allocated to all operators across all telecom circles in India. CVoter ensures proper representative analysis by statistical weighing of the data to make it representative of the local population as per the latest census figures. The data is weighted to known census profiles, including gender, age, education, income, religion, caste, urban/ rural and vote recalls for the last Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabha elections. For the analytics, CVoter uses its proprietary algorithm to calculate the provincial and regional vote share based on the split-voter phenomenon.

CVoter follows the code of professional ethics and practices drafted by the World Association of Public Opinion Research and the official guidelines on opinion polling as instructed by Press Council of India.